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INDIAN SAFETY RATINGS FOR CARS

THE BHARAT NEW CAR ASSESSMENT PROGRAM RATES THEM FOR BOTH ADULT AND CHILD OCCUPANT PROTECTION



Good news folks—BNCAP or the Bharat New Car Assessment Program is here and the first to be rated under it is the Tata Harrier/Safari family, which has got a five-star rating for both Adult Occupant Protection (AOP) as well as for Child Occupant Protection (COP). That is the good news, but what does it mean?

First and foremost, BNCAP is a voluntary programme, which means it is not mandatory for car manufacturers to give their cars for crash testing to get a BNCAP safety rating. They may get their vehicles crash-tested and evaluated if they want to. And why would they want to? To instil a sense of confidence among the car-buying public that the car is safe and also because they have to pay a fraction of the cost to get a safety rating from BNCAP as opposed to other new car assessment programmes, specifically Global NCAP. After all five stars do seem to be the pinnacle of all ratings.

BNCAP IS A VOLUNTARY PROGRAMME AND THE TATA HARRIER/SAFARI FAMILY, WHICH IS THE FIRST CAR TO BE RATED UNDER IT, GOT FIVE STARS

Under Bharat NCAP, cars will be rated for AOP and awarded points out of 32, while for COP it will be out of 49. AOP comprises 16 points for the frontal offset deformable barrier test that will be carried out at a speed of 64 kmph, while the remaining 16 points will be awarded for the side impact test, again comprising the side moveable deformable barrier test carried out at 54 kmph and the pole side impact test that is carried out at 29 kmph. The 49 points for COP are divided into 24 for the dynamic score, another 12 for the installation of child restraint systems and the final 13 for vehicle assessment.

Cars are awarded five stars if their scores are above 27 for AOP and 41 for COP. Four stars are awarded for scores of over 22 and 35 respectively, and three for 16 and 27 points, two for 10 and 18 and finally one for a four-point score for AOP and a nine-point score for COP.

To understand the star ratings one has to realise that they are not absolute but mirror just the three most common scenarios of crashes out of a multitude. And even in these, a five-star rating does not mean that the car is indestructible or will save the passengers in every crash, or that a car with a three or a lower star rating is a death trap. The levels of protection are dependent on the use of seat belts for all passengers. Similarly, for COP, the child safety restraint systems are pointless if not used.

What one must also realise is that building in higher safety increases not only the cost of the car, but also its running costs with increase in weight. It is a compromise that all car makers are confronted with, especially in a very price-conscious and fuel-efficiency-sensitive market like India. The BNCAP's low cost will hopefully encourage more car makers to go in for crash test worthiness ratings, but given the prevailing sentiment, what may dissuade them is the possibility of scoring lower than five stars even though it might not actually mean much. What will be interesting, though, is if the government makes safety ratings mandatory, as it has done with energy efficiency ratings for home appliances. ■